

HSBC Holdings plc (0005)

Robust 4Q25 results and upbeat guidance set stage for further upside

Our take: 4Q25 results and management guidance for FY26 to FY28 beat expectations. We expect a positive stock reaction for the following reasons. **First**, HSBC's 4Q revenue and underlying PBT beat consensus by 3% and 9%, respectively, and the CET1 ratio of 14.9% is ahead of consensus by 20bps. The solid print was driven mainly by banking NII, which is 6% ahead, supported by robust deposit growth, higher HIBOR, and lower credit costs with impairment charges 12% below expectations. **Second**, there is stabilization in HK CRE asset quality (Table 5), with declining Stage 2 loans and stable Stage 3 loans q/q. With an improving housing market in HK and provision and capital coverage on HK CRE Stage 3 loans at 74%, we believe the drag on earnings is easing. **Third**, management guidance surprised to the upside. HSBC's updated 3Y (26e–28e) ROTE guidance is 17% or better, vs the previous target (25e–27e) of “mid-teens,” and ahead of cons ROTE of 16.6% in 26e, 17.0% in 27e, and JPMe 28e ROTE of 16.4%. And HSBC expects revenue growth to reach 5% by 2028, ahead of BBG consensus and JPMe of 4%/3%, respectively. Such robust guidance is likely supported by better banking NII, which is expected to be at least US\$45bn in 2026 (vs consensus US\$43.5bn). We note a strong rebound in HSBC's deposits (+8% y/y) and interest-earning assets growth (+4% y/y) in 2025, setting a solid base for banking NII growth. **Fourth**, more clarity on Hang Seng Bank: the Group targets benefits of \$0.9bn by 28e, including \$0.3bn cost savings, \$0.2bn revenue synergies, and \$0.4bn of additional revenue and cost optimization. We calculate that this adds ~40bps to 28e ROTE. Though, we expect management to provide more details on the path to achieving synergies and unlocking potential revenue upside with Hang Seng Bank. **Fifth**, we expect mid- to high-single-digit revisions to consensus EPS, and we could see an earlier return to share buybacks in 1Q26 compared to previous guidance of 2Q26. Retain OW rating.

Noteworthy areas

- **What do we like:** **1)** Banking NII of \$11.7bn was +6% ahead of company-compiled consensus, with interest-earning assets largely stable q/q. Customer lending +1% q/q driven by UK mortgages and Commercial while International Wealth with HK weaker, and Customer accounts +3% q/q with growth across divisions with HK +\$24bn q/q, CIB +\$11bn q/q, UK +\$8bn q/q and International Wealth +\$7bn q/q. **2)** Costs of \$8.9bn were in line with PPOP of \$8.8bn 7% above consensus. **3)** Impairments of \$0.9bn (36bps CoR) were 12% below consensus. **4)** PBT (clean) of \$8.6bn was 9% above consensus while stated PBT of \$6.8bn was 18% below consensus. **5)** CET1 of 14.9% was c20bps above consensus with DPS of 45c vs consensus 42c. **6)** TNAV/Sh of \$9.64

See page 7 for analyst certification and important disclosures, including non-US analyst disclosures.

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Overweight

0005.HK, 5 HK

Price: HK\$135.30

24 Feb 2026

Price Target: HK\$165.00

PT End Date: 31 Dec 2026

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(+42c q/q) was 3% above consensus.

- **What we don't like:** 1) Fee & Other income of \$6.0bn was 1% below consensus with a) Transaction Banking fee income 2% above consensus (+3% y/y), b) Wealth income 1% below consensus (+22% y/y) with growth in all products (including Investment Distribution +14% y/y, Insurance +49% y/y). The Group saw \$7bn of net new invested assets including \$3bn outflows in Asia (vs \$5bn/-\$2bn in 4Q24, \$29bn/\$15bn in 3Q25). Other income within Fees was 10% below consensus.

Forward looking points beat expectation

- **Outlook & Guidance in 2026:** 1) Banking NII of at least \$45bn (vs consensus \$43.51bn, JPMe \$43.379bn) reflecting deposit growth, hedge contributions and forward rates (below 4Q average/exit rates); 2) Cost growth of c1% from a baseline of \$33.5bn (implied at \$33.8bn) vs consensus \$34.3bn; 3) ECL of c40bps (in line); 4) CET1 14-14.5% target range; 5) Simplification savings: c\$1.5bn savings from re-organisation to be delivered by YE26 (cumulative of \$1.3bn/\$1.5bn in-year 26/27E), with \$0.8bn restructuring expected in 26E. Reallocation of savings: \$1.8bn to be reallocated prev \$1.5bn) with the increase driven by HSB privatisation; 6) Notables: -\$0.7bn Fee and other income in 26E (\$0.4bn from potential sale of Malta, \$(0.2)bn from UK life insurance, \$(0.1)bn from South Africa and +\$0.1bn from Germany custody business), -\$0.6bn restructuring costs related to Hang Seng Bank by YE28.
- **Targets across 26-28E:** 1) Year on year revenue growth across 26-28E, rising to 5% revenue growth in 28E ex notables and constant currency (vs consensus +1.5% 26E, +3.5% 27E, +4.2% 28E BBG); 2) ROTE 17% or better ex notables for 26-28E (vs cons 16.6% 26E, 17.0% 27E, 16.6% 28E JPMe); 3) Dividend payout ratio of 50% excluding material notable items.
- **Hang Seng privatization:** 1) Targeted benefits of \$0.9bn by 28E o.w. \$0.5bn synergies including \$0.3bn costs, \$0.4bn of additional revenue and cost opportunities; 2) Net CET1 impact of 110bps, with day 1 capital impact of -120bps partly offset by 10bps of hedging market risk RWAs in 1Q; 3) Restructuring of \$0.6bn; 4) Mgmt see this as more accretive than a SBB with the recognition of minority interest P&L (\$0.8bn) and expected synergies (\$0.5bn).
- **Likely changes to consensus:** Overall, we expect MSD% upgrades to consensus EPS for 26E driven by a stronger outlook for Banking NII and tighter cost management, with some upgrades to flow into outer years.

Others

- **Read-across to HK banks – positive:** Hong Kong business banking NII rose by 12% q/q with flattish loan balance, indicating increase in banking NIM. Average 1M HIBOR was up 117bps q/q in 4Q25, and CASA ratio for HK deposits is stable q/q at 64% in 4Q25. Fee and other income grew

by 5% y/y, led by robust momentum in wealth (+10% y/y) despite weak seasonality. Transaction banking revenue edged up 2% y/y. Asset quality in HK CRE was largely stable, with Stage 3 ratio edging up by 11bps q/q, while Stage 2 ratio declined by 6ppts q/q.

- **HK CRE – manageable risks with declined exposure and high provision:** At 4Q25, HK CRE excluding mainland China borrowers accounted for 3.1% of total loan book, down from 3.2% at 3Q25. The impaired loan ratio stayed largely flat q/q at 20.6% at 4Q25, while the sub-standard loan ratio down by 0.3pcts q/q to 7.8%. We note that 43% of the HK CRE book is unsecured, which remained stable in quality with limited credit impaired levels and close to 89% rated Strong or Good (vs 92% in 3Q), as unsecured loans are typically granted to conglomerate groups with diverse cashflows. The LTV for substandard and impaired HK CRE loan is 42% and 71%, respectively, at 4Q25. Loan loss reserve for HK CRE loans is at 3.5% in 4Q25, up from 3.4% in 3Q25. LLR for impaired loans with LTV>70% is high at 47% (0.9bn allowance over 1.9bn impaired loans with LTV>70%). In terms of HSB's HK CRE portfolio (\$15bn, 49% of total HK CRE exposure), the sub-standard and impaired loan ratio were at 11%/23% respectively in 4Q, higher than the group level, while it retained higher LLR ratio at 4.7% (vs overall 3.5%). The LLR for HK CRE impaired loans with LTV >70% was at 55% for HSB's exposure (vs overall 47%).
- **Asia business review:** Asia PBT growth was +6% y/y in 4Q25, slightly decelerating from 7% y/y in 3Q25. Total income was up 5% y/y (-4% q/q) while clean cost up 6% y/y (+7% q/q), delivering negative jaws, and thus PPoP was up by ~5% y/y. Loan impairment decreased by -21% y/y, bringing annualized credit cost down -11bps y/y to 37bps in 4Q25. Loan growth of +2% q/q (or +4% y/y) was ahead of the Group trend of +1% q/q, and deposits grew by 3% q/q (+8% y/y).
- **Conference Call Details:** 7.45 am GMT / 3.45 pm HKT on 25 Feb 2025; UK: +44 208 080 6592, HK: +852 3002 4428; Webinar ID: 963 1490 6482, Passcode: 297491.

Table 1: HSBC Group 4Q25 summary

HSBC Group (US\$ mil)	4Q24	3Q25	4Q25E	4Q25 cons	4Q25A	Y/Y	Q/Q	vs cons	vs JPMe
Banking NII	10,904	11,049	11,064	11,057	11,722	8%	6%	6%	6%
Fee and other income	5,600	6,851	5,697	6,088	6,001	7%	-12%	-1%	5%
o.w. Transaction Banking	2,532	2,608	2,380	2,571	2,615	3%	0%	2%	10%
o.w. Wealth	1,758	2,680	2,122	2,176	2,145	22%	-20%	-1%	1%
o.w. Other	1,310	1,563	1,195	1,372	1,241	-5%	-21%	-10%	4%
Underlying revenues	16,504	17,900	16,761	17,145	17,723	7%	-1%	3%	6%
Underlying costs (inc levy)	(8,498)	(8,380)	(8,978)	(8,920)	(8,905)	5%	6%	0%	-1%
Pre-provision profit	8,006	9,520	7,784	8,225	8,818	10%	-7%	7%	13%
Loan loss provision charge	(1,362)	(1,008)	(1,004)	(1,020)	(901)	-34%	-11%	-12%	-10%
Operating profit before tax	6,644	8,512	6,780	7,205	7,917	19%	-7%	10%	17%
Associate income	679	591	612	648	669	-1%	13%	3%	9%
Clean pretax profit	7,323	9,103	7,391	7,853	8,586	17%	-6%	9%	16%
Exceptionals and other one-offs (inc CTA)	(5,046)	(1,808)	(2,091)	(2,097)	(1,784)	-65%	-1%	-15%	-15%
Pre-tax profit	2,277	7,295	5,300	5,756	6,802	199%	-7%	18%	28%
DPS (\$)	0.36	0.10	0.42	0.42	0.45	25%	350%	7%	7%
TNAV/sh (\$)	8.61	9.22	9.25	9.38	9.64	12%	5%	3%	4%
B3 CET1 ratio transitional	14.9%	14.5%	14.6%	14.7%	14.9%	0 bps	36 bps	20 bps	28 bps
Loans (gross) (US\$bn)	940	993	982	979	999	6%	1%	2%	2%
Deposits (US\$bn)	1,655	1,737	1,718	1,745	1,787	8%	3%	2%	4%

Source: J.P. Morgan estimates, company data, company compiled consensus.

Table 2: HSBC Asia 4Q25 summary

Asia (US\$ mil)	4Q24A	1Q25A	2Q25A	3Q25A	4Q25A
Total income	8,324	9,382	7,957	9,140	8,775
Total clean costs	(3,859)	(3,538)	(3,765)	(3,797)	(4,081)
PPOP	4,465	5,844	4,192	5,343	4,694
Loan impairments & other impairments	(541)	(353)	(557)	(298)	(427)
Associate profits	541	635	(377)	406	486
Clean PBT	4,465	6,126	3,258	5,451	4,753
Exceptional items	0	0	0	0	0
Stated PBT	4,465	6,126	3,258	5,451	4,753
Loans (net)	449,940	453,681	459,814	460,790	467,842
Deposits	845,284	839,433	871,247	882,380	911,725
RWA	402,847	407,315	416,794	412,904	411,824
NIM (HBAP)	1.63%	NA	NA	NA	NA
Credit Costs (ann)	0.48%	0.31%	0.49%	0.26%	0.37%
Y/Y change					
Total income	7.0%	10.8%	-6.3%	4.3%	5.4%
Total clean costs	9.6%	5.5%	6.2%	6.3%	5.8%
PPOP	4.9%	14.2%	-15.3%	2.9%	5.1%
Loan impairments & other impairments	23.8%	30.3%	202.7%	-44.4%	-21.1%
Associate profits	13.2%	3.9%	-156.4%	-11.2%	-10.2%
Clean PBT	3.9%	12.3%	-40.1%	6.6%	6.5%
Exceptional items	-100.0%	NA	NA	NA	NA
Stated PBT	282.6%	12.3%	-40.1%	6.6%	6.5%
NIM (HBAP)	-10 bps	NA	NA	NA	NA
Credit Costs (ann)	9 bps	7 bps	32 bps	-21 bps	-11 bps
Q/Q change					
Loans (net)	-2.34%	0.83%	1.35%	0.21%	1.53%
Deposits	1.12%	-0.69%	3.79%	1.28%	3.33%
RWA	-2.12%	1.11%	2.33%	-0.93%	-0.26%

Source: Company data.

Table 3: HSBC Asia revenue by segment

Asia (US\$ mil)	4Q24	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	Q/Q	Y/Y
Segment Revenue in Asia (clean)							
HK business	3,890	4,079	3,919	4,042	4,142	2%	6%
Retail Banking and Wealth	2,388	2,551	2,443	2,570	2,618	2%	10%
Commercial Banking	1,502	1,528	1,476	1,472	1,524	4%	1%
CIB	3,059	3,471	3,287	3,201	3,076	-4%	1%
IWPB	1,450	1,847	1,764	2,035	1,759	-14%	21%
Corporate Centre	(75)	(15)	(1,013)	(138)	(202)	46%	169%
Total	12,214	13,461	11,876	13,182	12,917	-2%	6%

Source: Company data.

Table 4: HSBC Hong Kong business

In US\$ mn	4Q24	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25
P&L items					
Banking NII	3,063	3,040	2,835	2,934	3,273
Fee and other income	757	966	1,007	1,030	793
Retail Banking and Wealth	502	661	701	748	548
Retail Banking	74	87	89	84	66
Wealth	416	546	555	646	459
Other	12	28	57	18	23
Commercial Banking	255	305	306	282	245
Wholesale Transaction Banking	179	176	185	187	182
Credit and Lending	19	27	16	17	18
Other	57	102	105	78	45
Revenue excluding notable items	3,820	4,006	3,842	3,964	4,066
Notable items	0	0	0	0	0
Revenue	3,820	4,006	3,842	3,964	4,066
ECL	(356)	(320)	(544)	(304)	(308)
Total operating expenses	(1,302)	(1,136)	(1,165)	(1,209)	(1,307)
Share of profit in associates and JVs less impairment	0	0	0	0	0
Profit/(loss) before tax	2,162	2,550	2,133	2,451	2,451
Y/Y growth					
Banking NII	1%	3%	-5%	-3%	7%
Fee and other income	25%	32%	30%	30%	5%
Wealth	63%	51%	38%	60%	10%
Wholesale Transaction Banking	4%	4%	4%	1%	2%
Revenue excluding notable items	5%	9%	2%	4%	6%
Total operating expenses	7%	0%	-4%	0%	0%
Profit/(loss) before tax	14%	10%	-13%	10%	13%
B/S items					
Net loans and advances to customers	235,208	233,054	230,139	229,574	229,491
Customer deposits	507,389	505,334	517,406	519,269	543,381
Risk-weighted assets	143,668	144,929	140,630	140,496	139,628
Q/Q growth					
Net loans and advances to customers	-0.1%	-0.9%	-1.3%	-0.2%	0.0%
Customer deposits	2.4%	-0.4%	2.4%	0.4%	4.6%
Risk-weighted assets	-2.0%	0.9%	-3.0%	-0.1%	-0.6%

Source: Company data.

Table 5: HSBC HK CRE exposure

US\$mn	1H24	2H24	1H25	3Q25	2H25
HK CRE net balance (excl. mainland China CRE booked in HK)	35,609	33,201	31,918	31,033	30,624
Stage 1	24,675	22,132	8,635	8,975	10,666
Stage 2	7,710	6,515	18,142	15,701	13,652
Stage 3	3,224	4,554	5,141	6,357	6,306
Allowance for ECL	258	405	877	1,062	1,077
Deduction in CET1 from excess of expected loss	3,050	3,125	3,475	3,460	3,593
HK CRE exposure as % of total	3.8%	3.5%	3.2%	3.2%	3.1%
Stage 2 loan ratio	21.7%	19.6%	56.8%	50.6%	44.6%
Stage 3 loan ratio	9.1%	13.7%	16.1%	20.5%	20.6%
LLR / Loans	0.7%	1.2%	2.7%	3.4%	3.5%
Coverage ratio on Stage 2&3 loans	2.4%	3.7%	3.8%	4.8%	5.4%
(EEL deduction + Allowance for ECL)/Stage 3 loans	103%	78%	85%	71%	74%

Source: Company data. Note: Excluding exposure to mainland China borrowers.

Investment Thesis

HSBC's self-help programs in the past decade have lifted normalized and through-the-cycle RoTE from 8% to 16%. This means that the adjusted dividend yield (including share buybacks [SBB]) will stay at ~8% after the rate cycle, on our estimates. Despite a three-quarter suspension in buybacks due to HSB privatization, we estimate HSBC's 2025-28 total shareholder return yield at 7-8% each year, the highest among our bank sector coverage in the Greater China region. We see declines in revenue in the medium term as a result of business disposals as well as rate cuts and loan growth also under pressure, but fee income will likely provide some support, given strong momentum in Transaction Banking and Wealth. The group's restructuring plan could benefit on the cost side, depending on scale. We expect 2025/26/27/28 RoTE (excluding notable items) to be 16.7%/16.4%/16.5%/16.6%, broadly in line with HSBC's mid-teens guidance. We rate HSBC Overweight.

Valuation

Our Dec-26 PT of HK\$165 is based on our DDM analysis, with NAV discounted back to Dec-26 from FY28E and a fair P/B of 1.9x. Our key assumptions are a normalized ROE of 15.1%, a long-term growth rate of 2.4% and a cost of capital of 9.1%.

Risks to Rating and Price Target

Key downside risks include:

- **Macroeconomic risks:** HSBC is exposed to GDP growth in Hong Kong SAR, Mainland China and the UK, as well as FX and cross-border/political risks, which could pose downside risks. Similarly, the global interest rate and inflation outlook could impact group margins, which may differ from our expectations.
- **EM outlook:** We expect the asset quality outlook to deteriorate and forecast CoR growth above normalized levels in the medium term – although we see both upside and downside risks to this. This includes specific areas such as China CRE, where the group has a large unsecured exposure, and Hong Kong CRE, where the portfolio has seen sharp deterioration.
- **Regulatory risks:** Regulatory risks include Basel 4, performance in BoE stress tests/*Comprehensive Capital Analysis and Review* (CCAR) and changes in capital regime.

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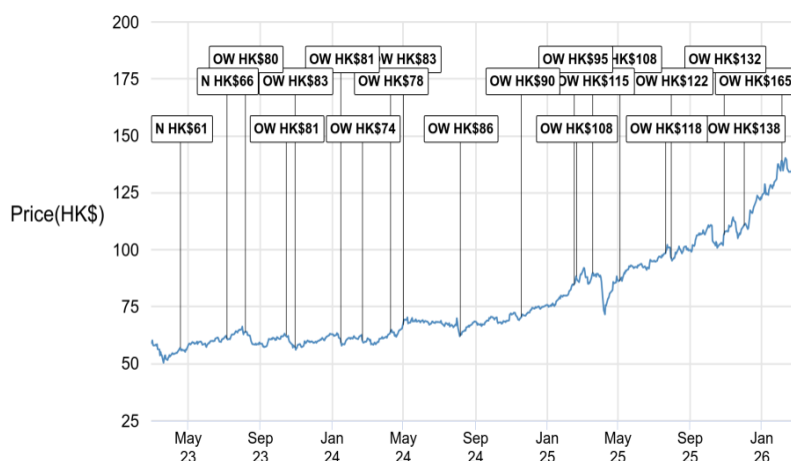
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HSBC Holdings plc (0005) (0005.HK, 5 HK) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Dec 31, 2000. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

Date	Rating	Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)
18-Apr-23	N	56.90	61
07-Jul-23	N	61.00	66
07-Aug-23	OW	63.85	80
16-Oct-23	OW	62.50	81
31-Oct-23	OW	57.20	83
17-Jan-24	OW	59.10	81
22-Feb-24	OW	60.25	74
10-Apr-24	OW	63.90	78
02-May-24	OW	67.00	83
06-Aug-24	OW	62.05	86
19-Nov-24	OW	70.55	90
17-Feb-25	OW	84.50	95
20-Feb-25	OW	88.40	108
20-Mar-25	OW	89.75	115
05-May-25	OW	86.20	108
22-Jul-25	OW	98.45	118
01-Aug-25	OW	96.15	122
30-Oct-25	OW	106.50	132
02-Dec-25	OW	110.50	138
05-Feb-26	OW	139.00	165

The chart(s) show J.P. Morgan's continuing coverage of the stocks; the current analysts may or may not have covered it over the entire period.

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